

Harsh Shah

Computer Engineering

Company: Barclays

Job Profile: Software Development Engineer (SDE)

Offer Type: Placement Only

CTC: ₹13.5 LPA

Location: Pune

Process Date: 26/07/2025 (OA) and 29/07/2025 (Interviews)

Resume: [Resume](#)

Placement Process:

1. Online Assessment [Number of candidates: 135]

The Online Assessment was a 90-minute test consisting of 15 questions:

- 13 questions were based on core CS subjects like Java, OOPS, DBMS, CN, and OS.
- 1 SQL question which was very simple, requiring the use of basic **WHERE** and **AND** conditions.
- 1 DSA coding question which was repeated from last year: [Lexicographically Smallest String After Applying Operations](#) ([JobOverflow link](#)).

Tips:

- Make sure to go through previous years' OA questions; the coding question may be repeated.
- Brush up on Java theory and basic DBMS/OOPS concepts.
- SQL basics (especially filtering rows using **WHERE** and logical operators) should be known.
- Practice DSA regularly using Striver's A-Z sheet to improve speed and accuracy.

2. Technical Interview Round 1 [Number of candidates: 37]

The round began with the interviewer looking at my resume. He asked me to explain any one of my projects. I picked one and walked him through it. He then asked if I had faced any challenges during the project. I mentioned encountering the CORS error, which I had seen in almost every project I built.

He asked how I resolved it. I explained that I used the `cors` library in the backend to allow the frontend domain to access backend resources. He seemed somewhat satisfied but pointed out that since CORS is a browser-based issue, I should reflect more on why the backend is used to resolve it.

He then asked whether I had used AI/ML in any of my projects. I mentioned that I had completed two college courses : Generative AI and LLMs, but had not integrated them into my projects.

Coding Questions:

He then gave two pattern-printing questions with the condition that I could use only two `for` loops in total.

Question 1 (n = 5):

```
*  
  
**  
  
***  
  
**  
  
*
```

I asked a few clarifying questions (like whether `n` is always odd) and wrote an example to confirm. I ended up using a `while` loop externally and nested `for` loops internally. The interviewer said this was partially correct, as the ideal solution required only two `for` loops total.

Question 2:

```
X*X*X  
  
X*X*  
  
X*X  
  
X*  
  
X
```

This one was easier. I solved it using two `for` loops and printed `X` for odd indices and `*` for even indices using the modulo operator. He was satisfied with my approach.

Java Concepts:

He asked whether Java was my primary language, and I confirmed it. Then he asked multiple Java-related questions:

- **HashMaps:** How are they implemented? I spoke about hashing techniques like linear probing and explained how linear probing works.
- **Time Complexities:** I said HashMap provides $O(1)$ average-case and $O(N)$ worst-case complexities. He asked whether search operations can also take $O(N)$, to which I answered yes, due to the linear scan in probing.
- **Hashing Properties:** I mentioned hashing should be low-cost and reduce collisions. He was looking for additional properties that I couldn't recall.
- **Primitive Data Types in HashMap:** I said Java does not allow primitive types, only wrapper classes. He asked how primitives are converted into objects, and I correctly answered "autoboxing."
- **List vs HashMap Search:** I said HashMap has better search performance ($O(1)$ avg) than a List ($O(N)$ worst).
- **TreeMap with Objects as Keys:** I said it is possible and explained by giving an example of a Person class, which contains name and age as attributed, and using a `TreeMap<Person, Integer>` with a lambda comparator, e.g., sorting by name using `a.name.compareTo(b.name)`. I also mentioned the need to override `hashCode()` and `equals()` methods in such classes.

The interviewer seemed moderately satisfied and selected me for the next round.

3. HR Interview [Number of candidates: 21]

This round was purely HR for me, while many others had a techno-HR round.

- The interviewer started by asking me to introduce myself. I included my internship experience at Triblet SportsTech, where I worked on UI/UX design using Figma.
- He asked what I would do if I didn't have access to Figma, Canva, or any other design tool. I said I would collaborate with my team and sketch designs manually, referring to existing designs from the internet.
- He asked if I had worked in a team. I replied yes and explained that I worked with two other teammates to design desktop and mobile layouts based on the company's theme.
- He inquired if there were any disagreements in the team. I shared a scenario where we had conflicting ideas about a design. I suggested we consult the founder/co-founder and some users to make an informed decision.

- He asked whether I ever took credit for someone else's work during my internship. I said no and gave an example of when I was helped by teammates and gave them full credit during a meeting with the founder.
- He presented a hypothetical: What would I do if I had to deliver a project in a week using C#, which neither I nor my team knew, and my teammates were busy? I responded that I'd learn the basics of C#, implement 2-3 core functionalities, and communicate with the project manager to request a 2-3 week extension while possibly offering extra features to make up for delays.
- Finally, he asked if I had taken undue credit during college. I honestly admitted that I once overstated my contribution to a major project presentation, but I later felt guilty and learned from the experience.

In total, 16 students were selected.

Useful Tips:

- **Strengthen Your Core Subjects:** Ensure you have a strong understanding of Computer Science fundamentals like OOPS, DBMS, OS, and CN. Many of the MCQs in the OA round and questions in technical interviews are directly based on these concepts.
- **DSA is Crucial:** Practice coding questions regularly. Completing Striver's A-Z DSA sheet is highly recommended. It will help not only for the OA but also for the technical interviews.
- **Java Concepts:** Since Java is a preferred language in many companies (including Barclays), you should know about its internal workings. Learn about JVM, JDK, JRE, memory model, autoboxing, generics, garbage collection, lambda expressions, comparators, TreeMaps, etc.
- **Aptitude Practice:** Don't ignore aptitude. Practice questions from IndiaBix and PrepInsta. They're helpful for logical reasoning and quick decision-making.
- **Competitive Programming:** While not mandatory, doing CP improves your problem-solving speed and ability to think under pressure. Start with the CP-31 sheet by TLE Eliminators. Try solving questions on platforms like CodeChef, CodeForces, and LeetCode regularly.
- **SQL & DBMS:** Basic SQL questions can be game-changers. Make sure you know how to use **SELECT**, **WHERE**, **AND**, and basic joins. Also, revise normalization, indexing, ACID properties, and ER diagrams.
- **Behavioral Round Prep:** Be honest. Your attitude and ability to work in teams matter just as much as your technical skills. Interviewers can detect fake responses.
- **Watch & Read:** For DBMS, OS, and other core topics, Love Babbar's playlists are very beginner-friendly. His notes are also helpful before interviews.
- **Stay Consistent & Positive:** Placement season is stressful. Not clearing a test or getting rejected after interviews is normal. Don't compare your journey with others.

Luck plays a role too, from the question you get in OA to which interviewer panel you face. Focus on continuous improvement.

- **Stay Connected:** Build a peer group that supports and motivates each other. Help your friends and ask for help too.
- **Final Word:** Never lose hope. Everyone gets placed at their own time. What matters is persistence and faith in your own abilities.

If you have any doubts or need help during your placement journey, feel free to reach out to me. I'm happy to help in any way I can. [Connect with me on LinkedIn](#)